



Te Tāhuhu o
te Mātauranga
Ministry of Education

Education Indicator

WORKFORCE

Early Childhood Education (ECE) teaching staff

In 2025, compared to 2024:

- the number of teaching staff increased by 1%,
- the number of home-based educators increased by 0.6%,
- the retention rate for permanent teaching staff increased by 2 percentage points.

Compared to 2019:

- the number of teaching staff had increased by 5%,
- the number of home-based educators decreased by 52%, and
- the retention rate increased by 4 percentage points.

Indicator description

This report presents three indicators of teaching staff in the early learning sector.^{1,2} The data used in these indicators are collected through the ECE Census, which is conducted in the last full week (that is the last week that does not contain a public holiday) of June every year.³

The three indicators are:

- **Number of teaching staff:** This is broken down by a range of characteristics, including qualifications, registration status, employment status (permanent or reliever), work hours (full-time/part-time), ethnicity and region.
- **Number of home-based educators:** This measure is broken down by a range of characteristics, including qualifications, registration status, employment status (permanent or casual/reliever), work hours (full-time or part-time), ethnicity and region.

¹ In this report, for most comparisons between years, we describe changes using percentage (%) increases or decreases to show changes in overall numbers. However, in cases where the focus is on differences in the percentage, we use percentage-point changes. The terms percentage and percentage point are used to make these distinctions.

² Teaching staff refers to ECE staff who have a teaching role in licensed ECE services—ECE teachers and home-based coordinators. This does not include kaiako in kōhanga reo.

³ This data is from the Ministry of Education's annual Early Childhood Census, taken 23-29 June 2025. It includes all licensed early childhood services (except for Kōhanga Reo) and Te Kura (the Correspondence School). For further information, please check [Education Counts](#).

- **Teaching staff retention and turnover rates:** The teaching staff retention rate is the percentage of teaching staff who remained employed in the same ECE service during the year. Turnover and retention rate are measured across two consecutive annual ECE Census returns. The inverse of the retention rate is the teaching staff turnover rate, which measures the percentage of early childhood teachers who left their employment at their ECE service. These measures are reported for permanent teaching staff (including home-based coordinators), with additional breakdowns by qualifications and region.

Why this is important

High-quality early learning is essential for children's lifelong learning, wellbeing and success. Teaching staff and leaders that are well-qualified, diverse, culturally competent and valued are at the heart of this quality.

Equity: Equity in early learning means ensuring every child can access high-quality, identity-affirming teaching. A diverse and well qualified workforce is essential for this (Ministry of Education, 2020). Teachers play a crucial role in creating inclusive environments where all tamariki feel valued. This requires strong cultural competence—supporting Māori to succeed as Māori, honouring Te Tiriti o Waitangi and embedding tikanga Māori in daily practice.⁴ Teachers must also recognise and celebrate the languages, cultures and identities of all children, so that learning is meaningful and affirming (Goldsmith et al., 2020). Strong partnerships with whānau are also vital, as family and community knowledge underpin children's learning and wellbeing. Research shows that culturally responsive pedagogy strengthens children's sense of belonging and identity, which supports both learning and wellbeing (Gordon-Burns & Campbell, 2014).

Qualifications: Teacher qualifications are central to quality in early learning. Initial Teacher Education (ITE) and ongoing certification shape teachers' professional knowledge and practice, preparing them to implement Te Whāriki in culturally responsive ways (Mitchell et al., 2008). Certification ensures teachers uphold the Code of Professional Responsibility and stay current with theory and practice. Research consistently links higher teacher qualifications with higher-quality early childhood environments and better outcomes for children (Saracho & Spodek, 2008). For home-based educators, accessible pathways to gain higher qualifications are essential to ensuring quality across all service types.

Teacher Movement: Teachers move and leave jobs for a variety of reasons. Some turnover is beneficial to both teachers and early learning services, allowing teachers to explore new career opportunities, and introducing new talent and ideas into early learning services. However, it is also important to retain skilled and experienced teachers. Monitoring turnover allows us to understand the stability of the teacher workforce, how it is changing over time and if there are any particular groups of teachers experiencing different rates of turnover. Research highlights that workforce shortages and high turnover remain persistent challenges internationally and in New Zealand, and that improving pay, conditions, opportunities for career progression and professional support is essential to sustaining a qualified workforce (OECD, 2025).

⁴ [Teaching Council of Aotearoa New Zealand - 2026 Standards of Teaching Profession](#)

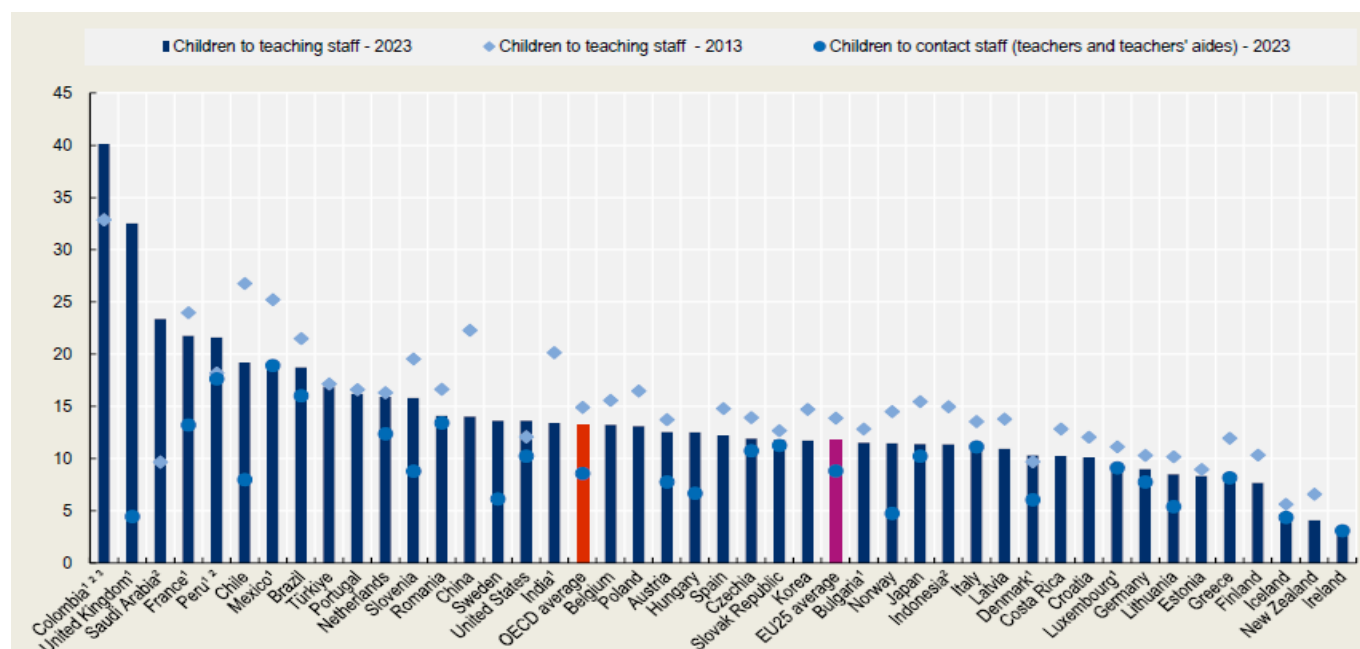
How does New Zealand compare internationally

The 2025 edition of the OECD's Education at a Glance, which is based on 2023 data, showed New Zealand's position against other OECD nations for child to staff ratios (Figure 1).

Overall, the ratio of children to teachers in pre-primary education (3 years to school age) fell across most OECD countries: from an average of 15 to 13 children per teacher.⁵ However, a few countries experienced increases in child-to-teacher ratios, due to rising enrolments and challenges in maintaining a sufficient teaching workforce (OECD, 2025). New Zealand had some of the lowest ratios for children to staff, with about 5 children of age 3 per teaching staff, and 6 children of age 4-6 years per teaching staff.

Child-to-staff ratios were lower for younger children in early childhood educational development programmes (0-2 years) than in pre-primary education, averaging 9:1 across OECD countries (OECD, 2025). In New Zealand, there were about 4 children of age 0-2 years per teaching staff.⁶

Figure 1: Ratio of children to staff in pre-primary education in OECD countries



⁵ Early childhood educational development refers to ISCED 01 programmes (targeted at children aged 0 to 2 years). For more information see and Pre-primary education corresponds to ISCED 02 programmes (targeted at children aged 3 years until the start of school or ISCED 1 programmes): [ISCED 0: Early childhood education](#)

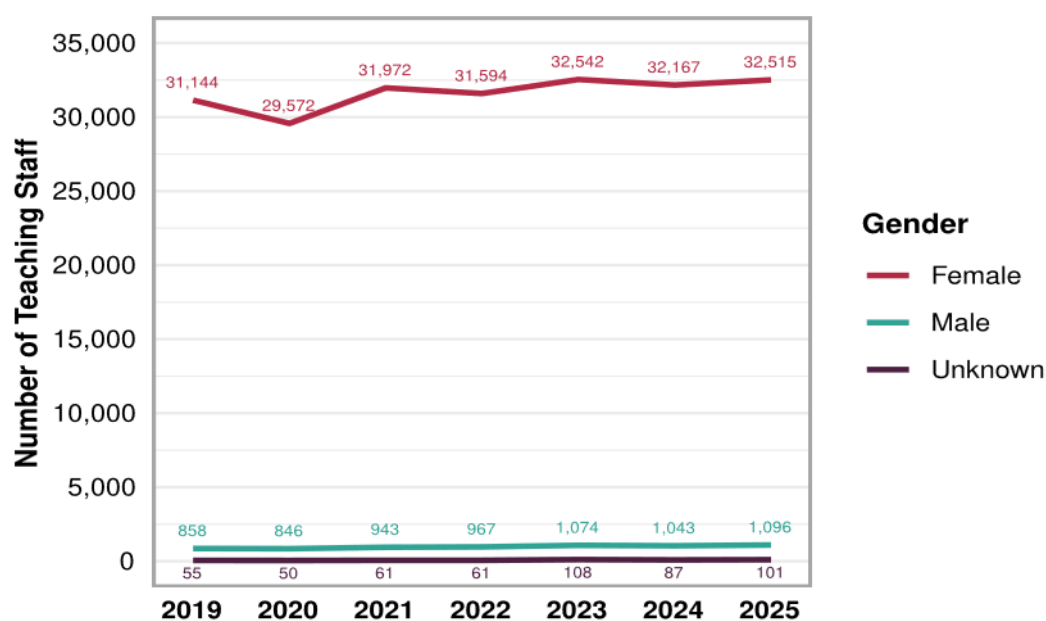
⁶ The OECD method for calculating child-staff ratios is slightly different from New Zealand reporting methods. In New Zealand, we look at the staff-child ratios during the busiest hours of the day rather than a ratio of the total count of staff and children followed by the OECD. There is no data point for "Children to contact staff (teachers and teachers' aides)" for New Zealand because within the New Zealand early childhood education context, teacher aides are not part of the staffing structure.

What happened to the number of teaching staff?

In 2025, there were 33,712 teaching staff in licensed ECE services, a 1% increase from 2024, and a 5% increase from 2019.

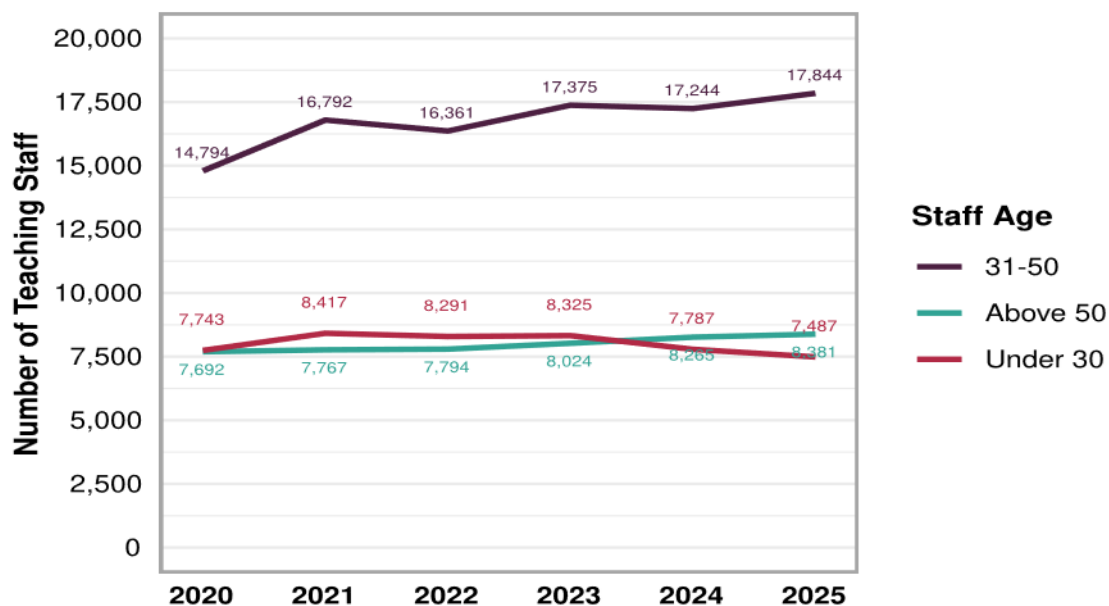
97% of teaching staff were female in 2025: a 1% increase in the number of female staff from 2024 and a 4% increase since 2019. In 2025, 3% of teaching staff were male: a 5% increase in the number of male staff from 2024 and a 28% increase since 2019. Figure 2 shows the breakdown of teaching staff by gender.

Figure 2: Teaching staff by gender and year



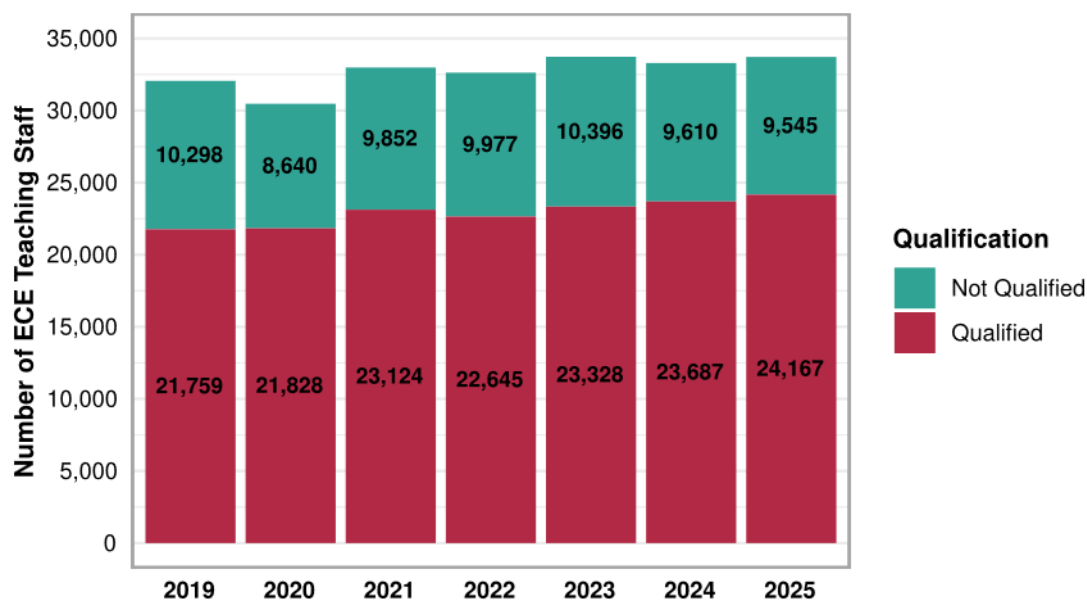
Most teaching staff were 31-50 years-old (53%), an increase of 21% from 2020. 25% were above 50 years of age, an increase of 9% from 2020. 22% of teaching staff were under 30 years of age, a decrease of 3% from 2020 (Figure 3).⁷

⁷ Information on age distribution of ECE teaching staff and educators has been collected and reported only from 2020 onward.

Figure 3: Teaching staff by age group

Qualification status⁸

Of the total teaching staff in 2025, 24,167 were qualified - 72% of all teaching staff. This was an increase of 2% from 2024 and an increase of 11% from 2019 (see Figure 4).

Figure 4: Teaching staff by qualification and year

⁸ To be qualified, teaching staff must hold a recognised ECE or Primary teaching qualification that leads to registration with the Teaching Council of Aotearoa New Zealand. Teaching staff are defined as those staff who have a teaching role – ECE teachers and home-based coordinators. Staff at Playcentre and home-based educators are not included in this definition. Data on kaiako at Kōhanga Reo is not included in the Ministry's ECE Census reporting.

Certification rates of ECE teaching staff have been consistently high for the last five years.⁹

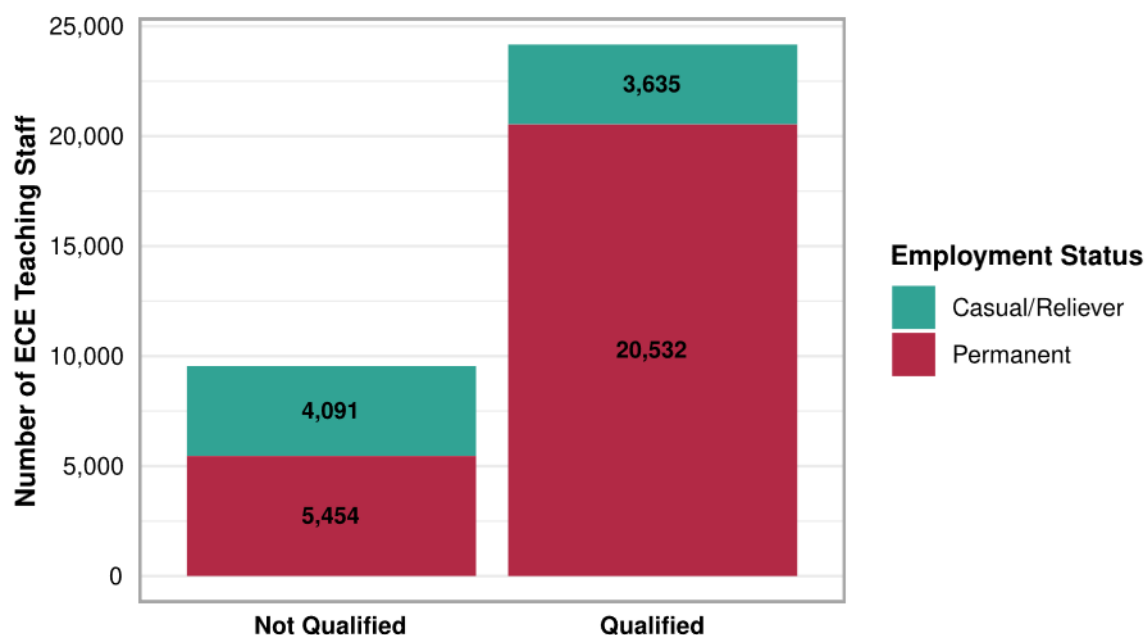
In 2025, there were 23,929 certificated ECE teaching staff - 71% of all ECE teaching staff. This was an increase of 1 percentage point from 2024 and an increase of 5 percentage points from 2019. Among qualified teaching staff, 99% had certifications in 2025, 99% in 2024 and 97% in 2019. To be certified, teaching staff will need to be qualified. As such, the number of qualified and certificated teachers are similar.

Employment status

Employment status refers to whether teaching staff are permanent employees or not. Casual/reliever staff include those who have a fixed-term contract, casual staff, relievers and agency relievers. There were 25,986 permanent ECE teaching staff and 7,726 casual teaching staff (or relievers) in 2025. The number of permanent teaching staff had an increase of 1% and the number of casual/reliever staff had an increase of 2% from 2024. In 2025, 77% of overall staff were permanent teaching staff, the same as in 2024, and 23% were casual/reliever teaching staff, the same as in 2024.

Qualified teaching staff were more likely than unqualified teaching staff to be permanent. Among qualified teaching staff, 85% were permanent teaching staff (an increase of 3% from 2024) and 15% were casual/relievers in 2025 (a decrease of 1% from 2024). Among unqualified teaching staff, 57% were permanent teaching staff (a decrease of 4% from 2024) and 43% were casual/relievers in 2025 (an increase of 4% from 2024). Figure 5 shows the breakdown of permanent and casual teaching staff in 2025.

Figure 5: Employment status of teaching staff by qualification

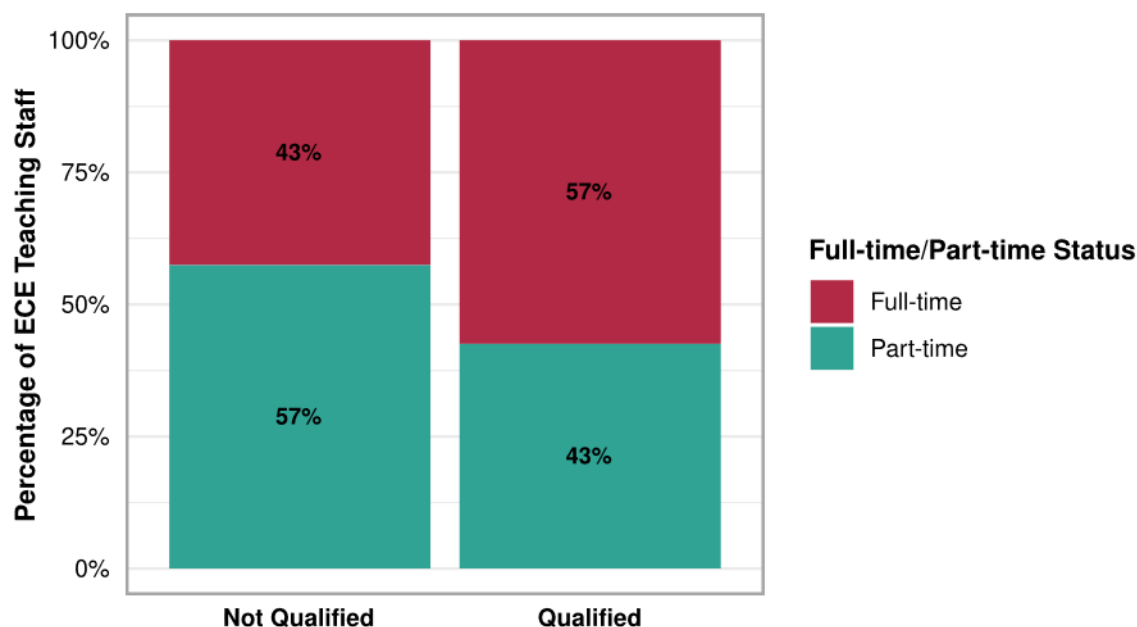


⁹ Certificated teaching staff include teaching staff that hold a Teaching Council of Aotearoa New Zealand practising certificate which is either provisional, subject to confirmation or with full certification status. Certificated teaching staff can also include primary or secondary certificated teachers.

Full-time/Part-time status

There were 17,967 full-time teaching staff in 2025—53% of all teaching staff.¹⁰ This was an increase of 1% from 2024 and an increase of 3% from 2019. In 2025, 13,903 (57%) of qualified teaching staff and 4,064 (43%) of unqualified teaching staff were working full-time (see Figure 6).

Figure 6: Full-time / part-time status of teaching staff by qualification



Ethnic groups

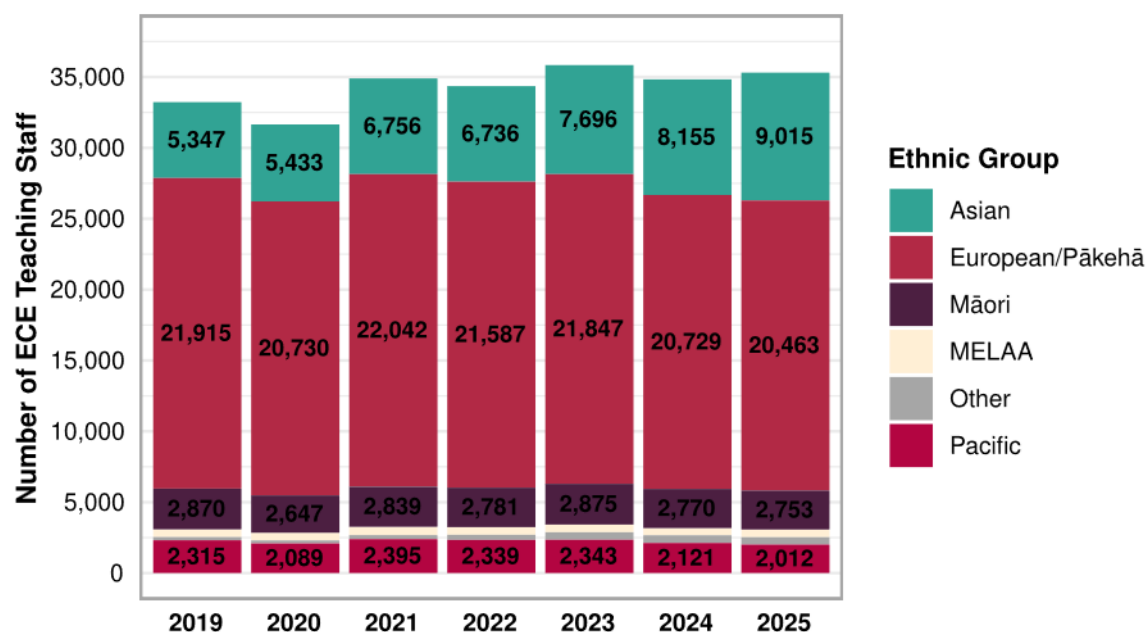
The majority (61%) of teaching staff were European/Pākehā. 27% were Asian, 8% Māori, 6% Pacific, 2% were Middle-Eastern, Latin American and African (MELAA) ethnicity, 2% were of other ethnicities and the remainder did not state their ethnicity.¹¹ Figure 7 shows the breakdown of teaching staff by ethnicity from 2019 to 2025.¹²

In 2025, nearly half or more teaching staff of all ethnicities were qualified: 74% European/Pākehā, 70% Asian, 68% Māori, 68% Pacific and 51% MELAA were qualified teaching staff.

¹⁰ Refers to whether teaching staff are working full-time or part-time. Full-time equates to 25 hours per week or more child contact time.

¹¹ This does not include kōhanga reo kaiako, who would be mostly of Māori ethnicity.

¹² Ethnicity information for ECE teaching staff has been collected and reported only from 2019 onward.

Figure 7: Ethnicity distribution of teaching staff by year

Service types

Most teaching staff were employed by education and care services (84%), followed by kindergartens (14%) and home-based services (2%).¹³ The remainder (0.4%) worked in casual education and care services, hospital-based services and Te Kura (the Correspondence School) (see Table 1).

Table 1: Number and percentage of teaching staff in each service type

Service type	Number of teaching staff	Qualified (%)	Certificated (%)	Permanent (%)	Full-time (%)
Education and care	28,412	68%	67%	79%	57%
Kindergarten	4,601	92%	92%	62%	30%
Home-based	562	100%	90%	93%	44%
Other	151	89%	89%	72%	32%

Regions

The majority of teaching staff were based in Auckland (35%), followed by Canterbury (13%), Waikato (11%) and Wellington (10%). The West Coast, Nelson, Marlborough, Gisborne and Tasman regions each accounted for about 1% of all teaching staff. Figure 8 shows the proportion of the total teaching staff that were qualified in each region.

¹³ 'Teaching staff' in home-based services refers only to the Visiting Teacher/Coordinator/Person Responsible role - which must be held by an ECE qualified teacher.

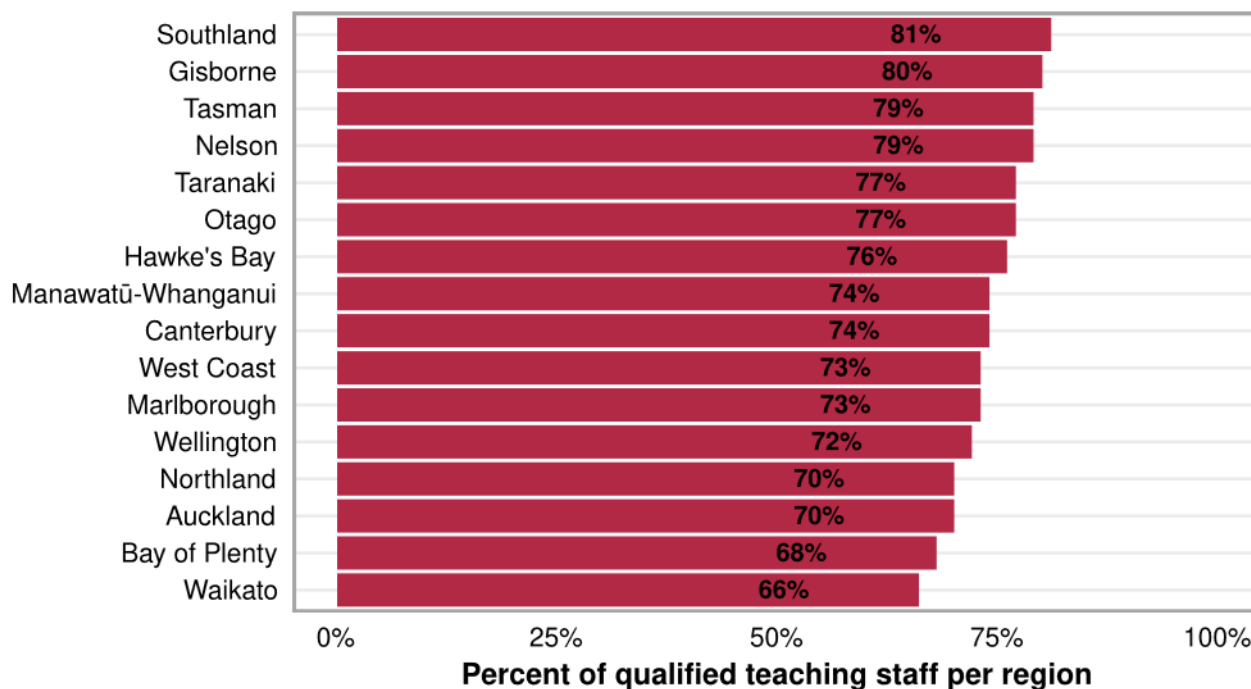
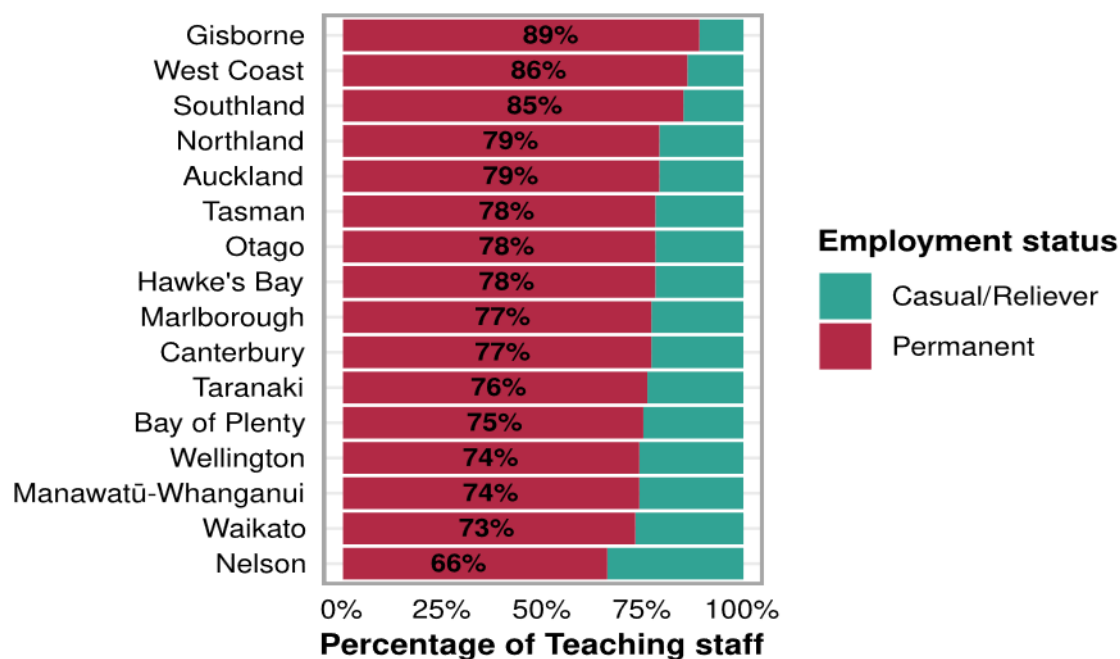
Figure 8: Percentage of qualified teaching staff in each region

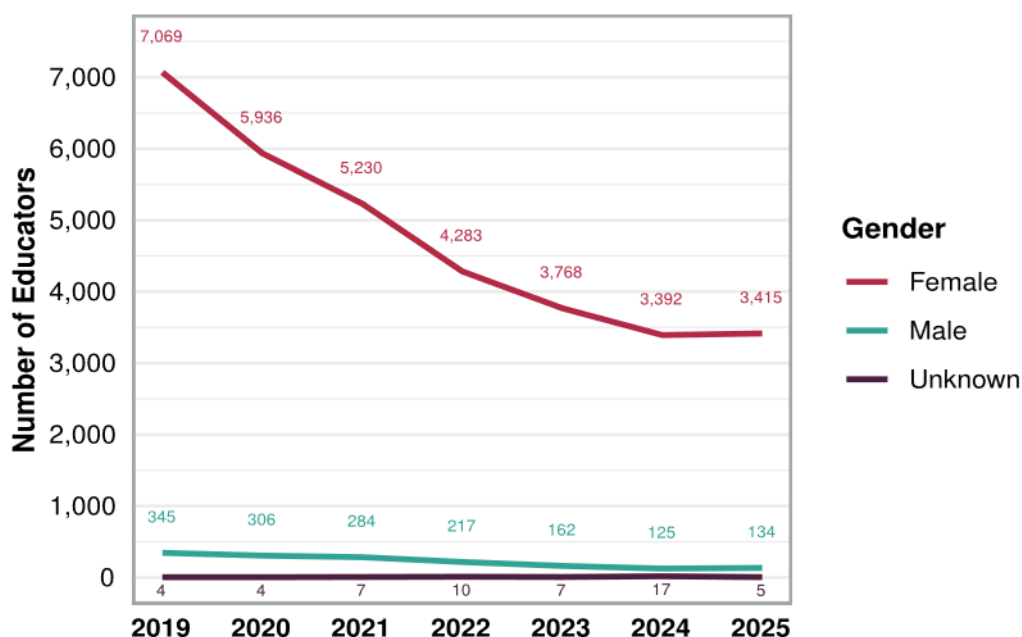
Figure 9 shows the distribution of permanent and casual/reliever teaching staff in different regions. Across all regions, at least 66% of teaching staff were permanent employees. Comparatively across all regions, only about 50% or fewer of the proportion of teaching staff were employed full-time.

Figure 9: Percentage of permanent and casual/reliever teaching staff in each region

What happened to home-based educators?¹⁴

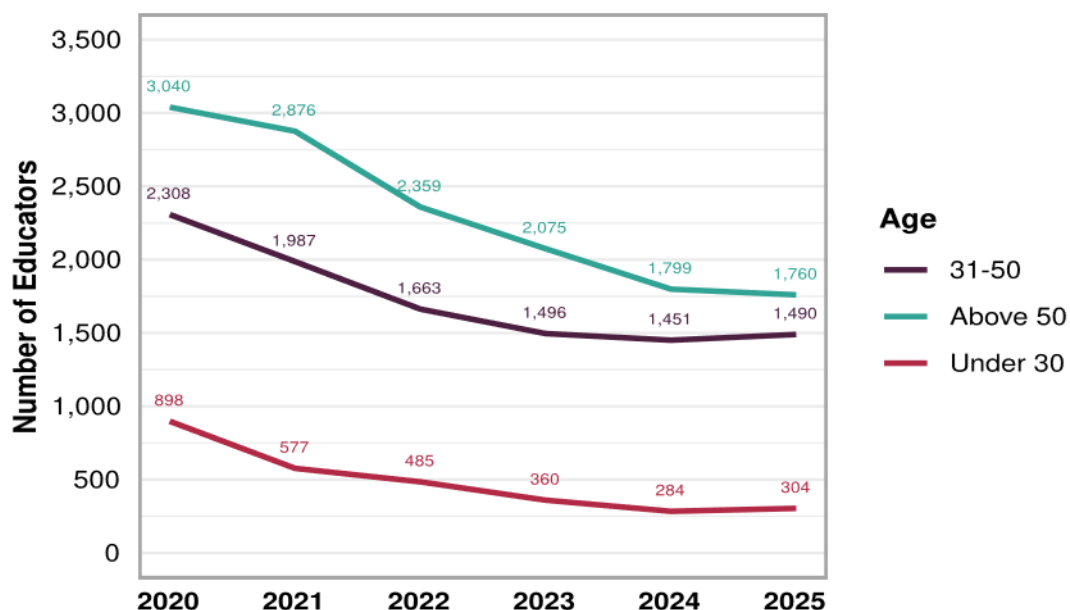
There were 3,554 educators in 2025, an increase of 0.6% from 2024. Compared to 2019, the number of educators had decreased by 52% in 2025. This was due to a large decrease in the total number of home-based services, over the past six years - a 47% decline of services from 2019. 96% of educators were female in 2025, an increase of 0.1 percentage point from 2024 (see Figure 10).

Figure 10: Home-based educators by gender and year



Most educators were above 50 years of age (50%), 42% were 31-50 years-old and 8% of educators were under 30 years of age (Figure 11).

Figure 11: Home-based educators by age group

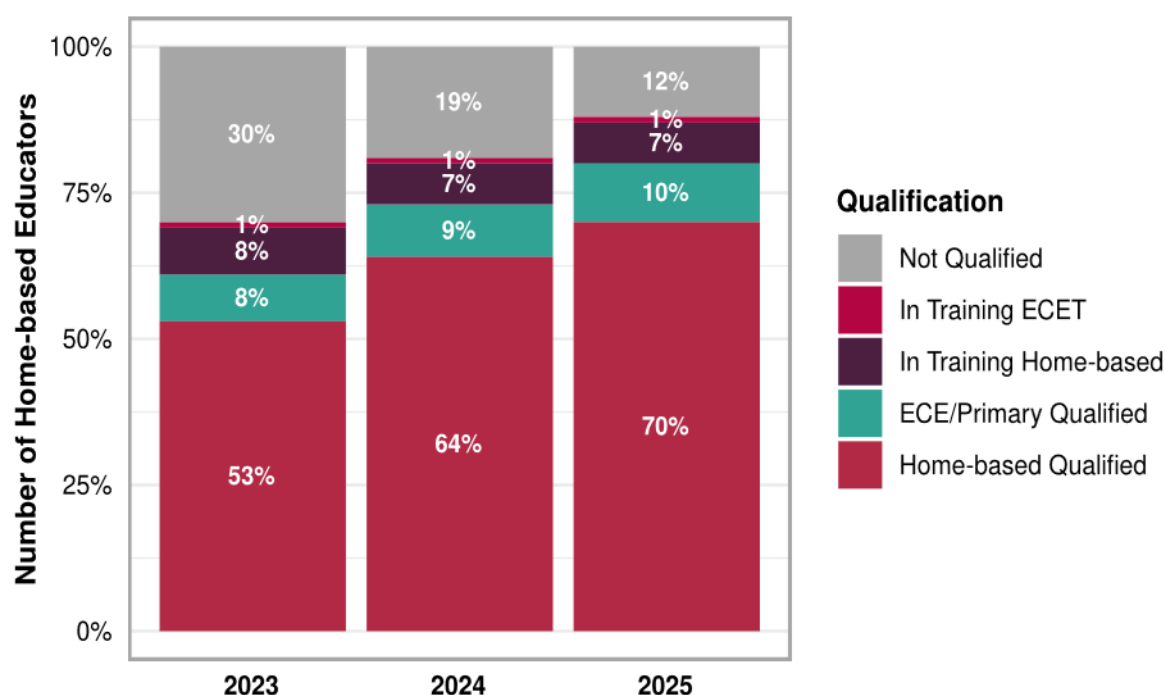


¹⁴ Home-based educator numbers are separate from teaching staff numbers. Qualified home-based educators hold either: Level 4/higher ECE qualifications; or a Level 3 ECE qualification completed before 1 June 2022; or a Primary teaching qualification; or Te Ara Tuarua or higher.

Qualification status¹⁵

Of all educators in 2025, 2,476 (70%) had home-based qualifications, 354 (10%) had ECE/primary qualifications, 249 (7%) were in training to become qualified home-based educators and 33 (1%) were in training to become an ECE teaching staff (Figure 12). The number of qualified home-based educators increased by 6 percentage points from 2024.

Figure 12: Home-based educators by qualification and year¹⁶



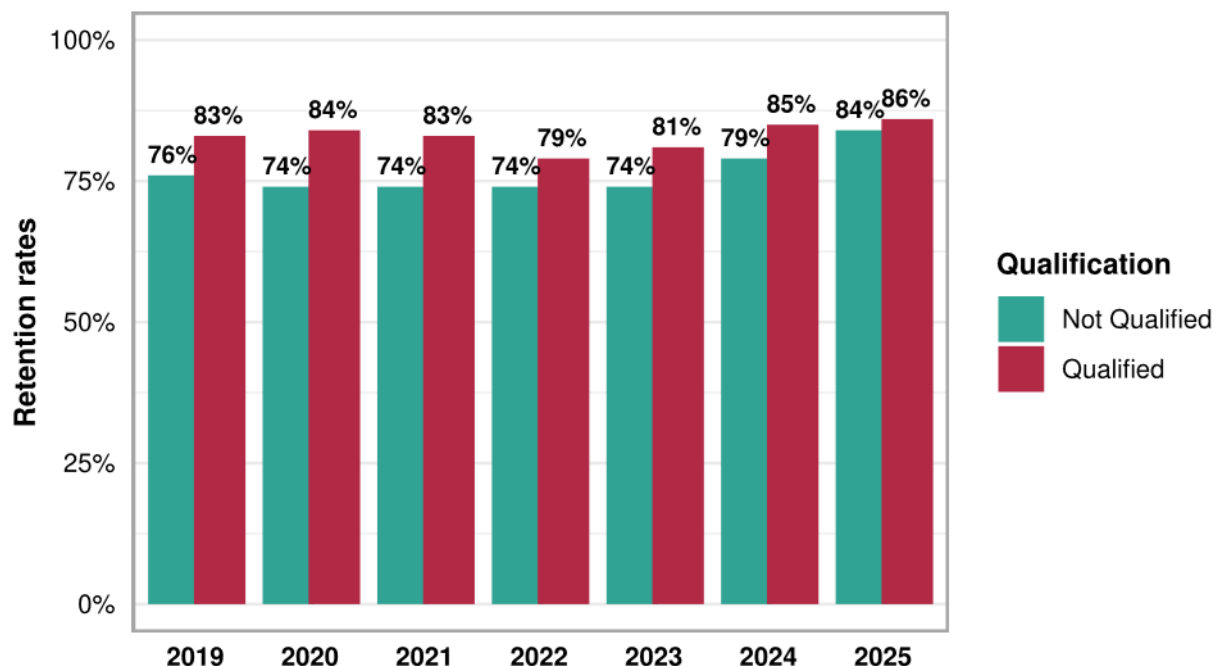
What was the teaching staff retention and turnover rate?

The teaching staff retention rate refers to the percentage of ECE teaching staff who remained employed in the same ECE service during the year. The retention rate for permanent teaching staff was 85% in 2025, an increase of 1 percentage point from 2024. In total, the retention rate increased by 4 percentage points from 2019.

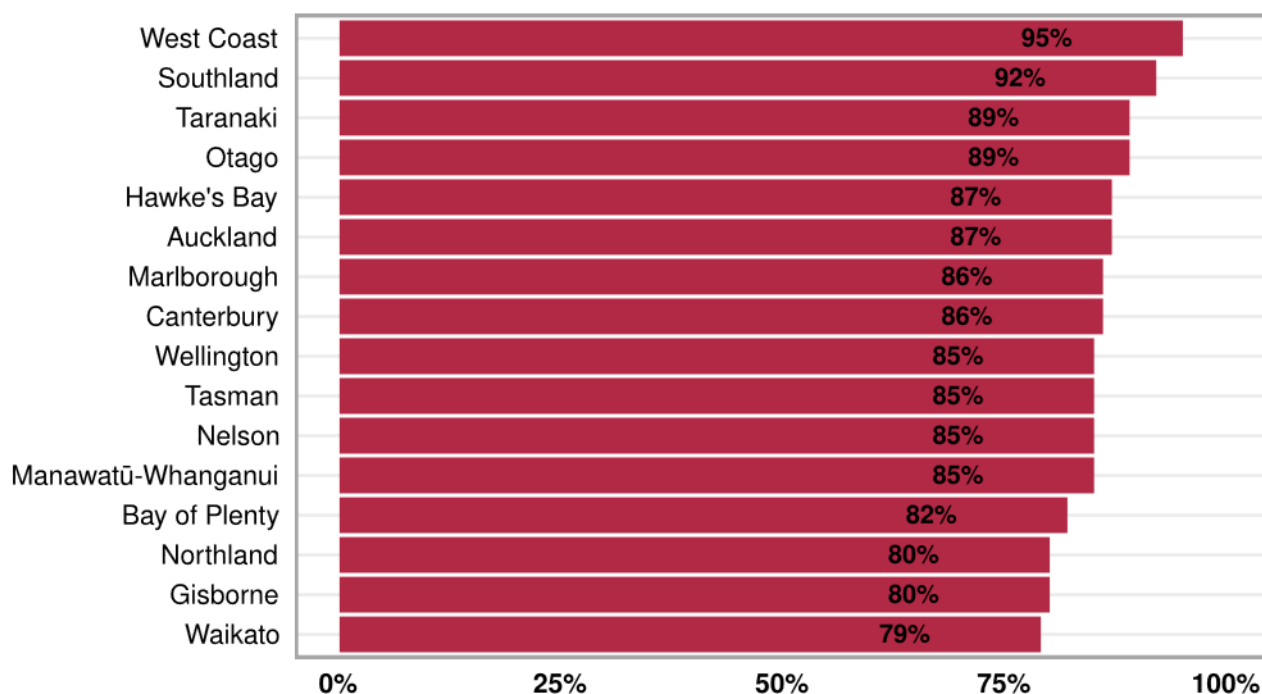
Among qualified teaching staff, the retention rate was 86% in 2025 and among unqualified teaching staff, it was 84%. Since 2019, retention rates of qualified staff were consistently slightly higher than those who were not qualified (Figure 13).

¹⁵ To be qualified, home-based educators must hold one of the following [recognised qualifications](#): a Level 4 or higher ECE qualification listed on the New Zealand Qualifications Framework or, an early childhood qualification recognised by the Teaching Council of Aotearoa New Zealand for registration purposes, or a Level 3 ECE qualification completed before 1 June 2022, or a primary teaching qualification, or a level 5, or above, qualification developed by Te Kōhanga Reo National Trust Board.

¹⁶ In Training ECET stands for 'In Training Early Childhood Education Teacher'.

Figure 13: Retention rates of teaching staff by qualification and year

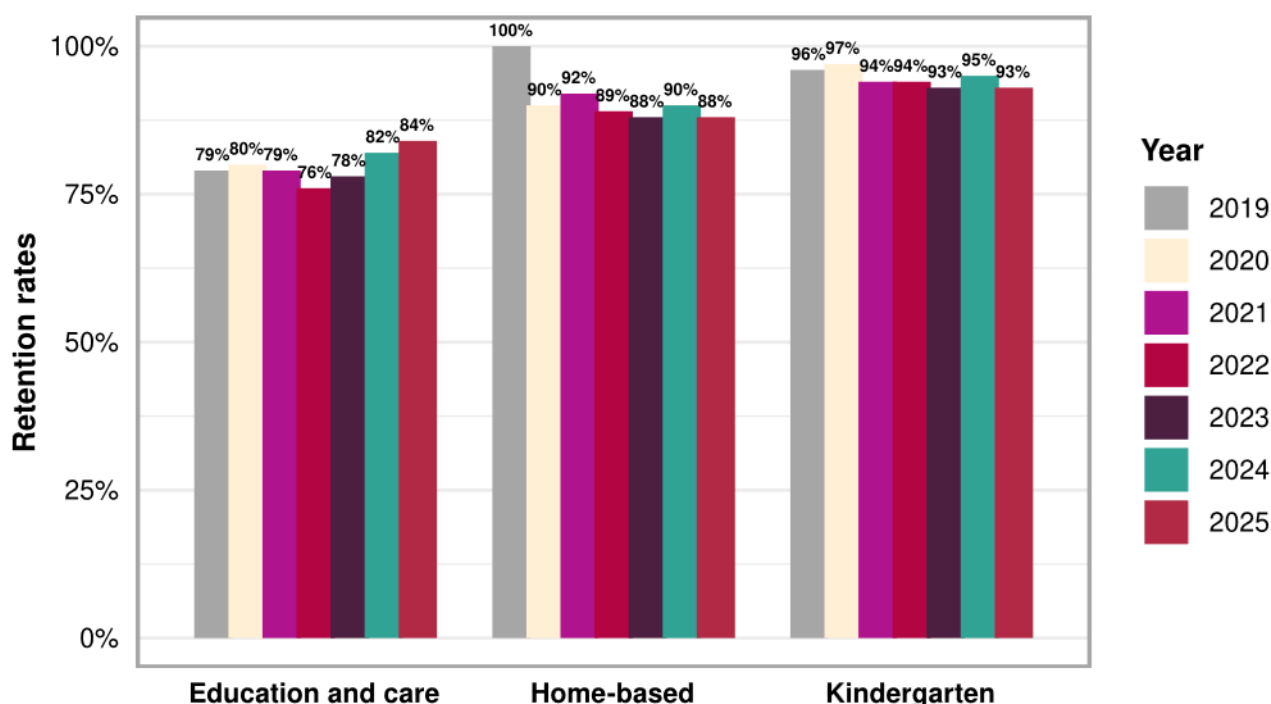
In 2025, the West Coast had the highest retention rate (95%) and Waikato had the lowest retention rate (79%). Figure 14 shows the 2025 retention rates of teaching staff for different regions.

Figure 14: Retention rates of teaching staff by region

In 2025 kindergartens had a retention rate of 93%, which was the highest rate of all service types. In comparison, at 84%, education and care services had a lower retention rate of permanent teaching staff. The higher retention rate of staff in kindergartens might be due to higher pay received by teaching staff, compared to other service types.¹⁷ Kindergartens also had a much higher proportion of qualified teaching staff (92%) than education and care services (68%). As qualified teaching staff have slightly higher retention rates (+2 percentage points), this might have been another factor contributing to the higher retention rate in kindergartens.

Figure 15 shows the retention rates of teaching staff (including home-based co-ordinators) by service types, for the last six years.

Figure 15: Retention rates of teaching staff by service type and year



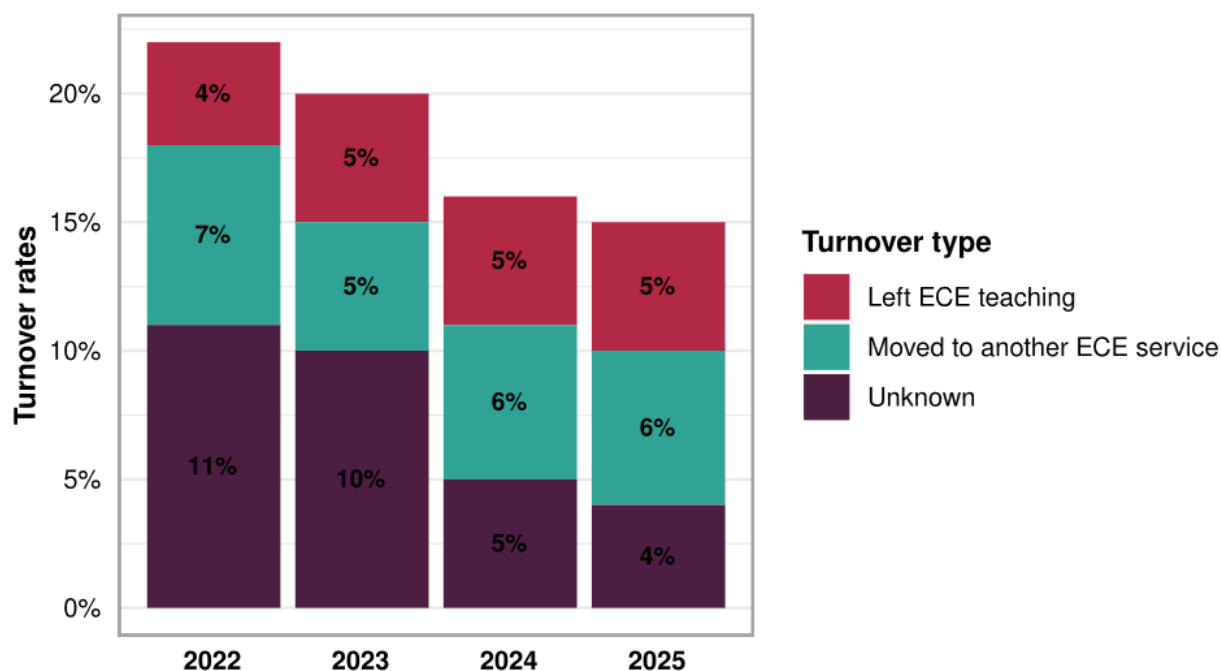
Turnover type¹⁸

The teaching staff turnover rate refers to the proportion of permanent teaching staff that left their roles in a year and is the inverse of retention. Teaching staff can leave a role to take up a different ECE teaching role or can leave ECE teaching altogether, either to retire, travel or to take up other employment. In very rare cases (<0.5% of staff), some teaching staff have left teaching to move to a non-teaching role within the ECE sector. As these teaching staff account for a very small proportion, for the purposes of this analysis, this type of turnover is included in the 'left ECE teaching' category

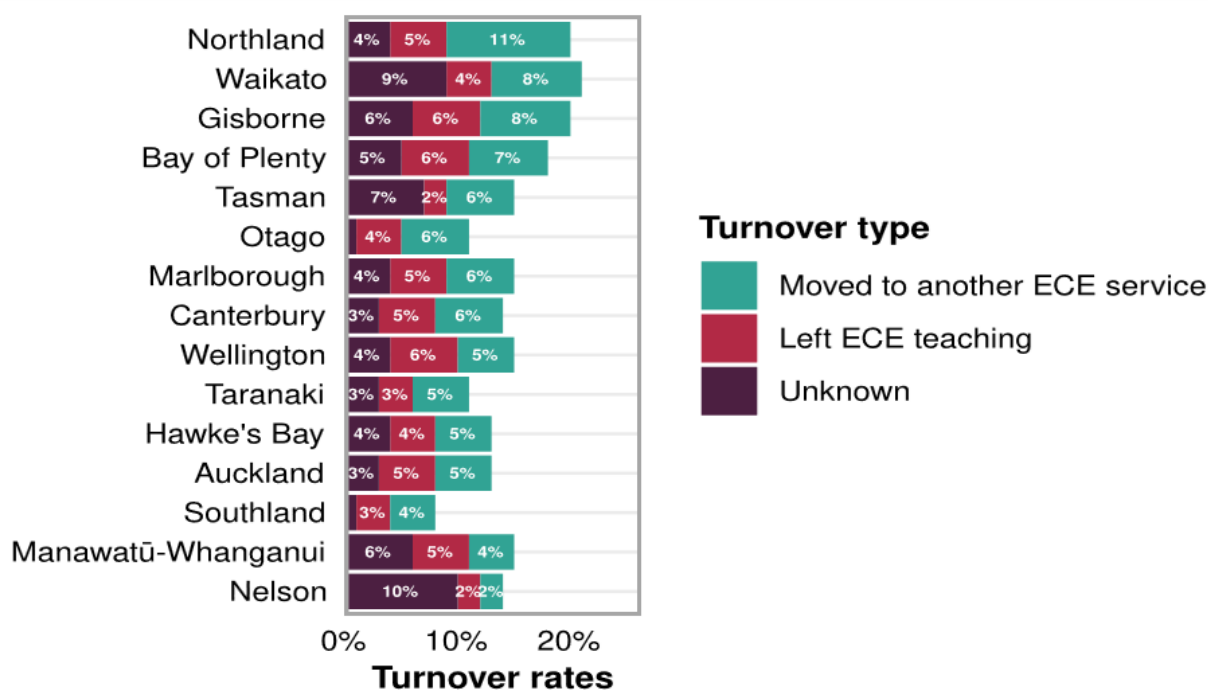
The turnover rate was 15% in 2025, a decrease of 1 percentage point from 2024. The greatest proportion of turnover among ECE teaching staff was due to teaching staff moving to another ECE service (6%), followed by teaching staff who left ECE teaching (5%). The reasons for the remaining turnover of teaching staff (4%) was unknown (this includes teaching staff who have left the ECE service they were employed at during the last census week, but their leaving destination was not collected or is unknown). Figure 16 shows the proportions of different types of turnover in the past four years.

¹⁷ [He Whakaaro: Estimating ECE teaching staff pay - 2018 to 2022](#)

¹⁸ Questions pertaining to teaching staff turnover were included in the ECE census from 2022.

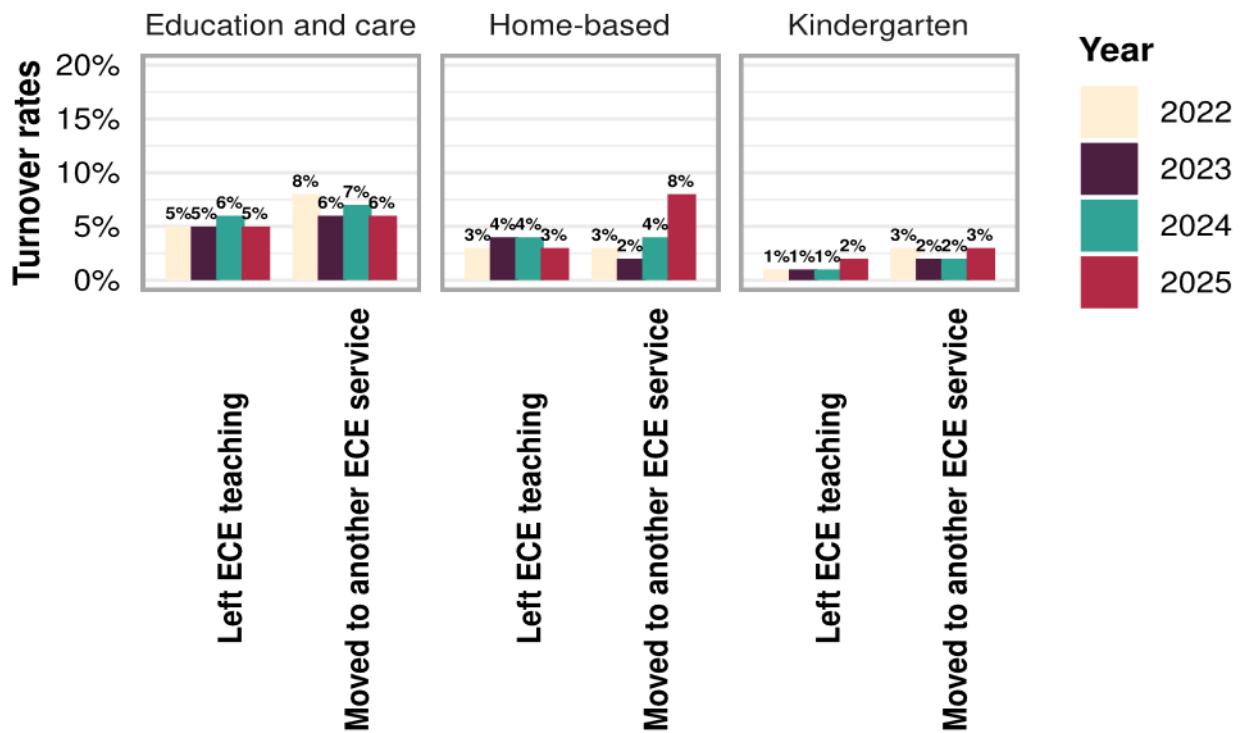
Figure 16: Types of turnover by year

In 2025, Northland had the highest turnover rate among teaching staff that moved to another ECE service, but Waikato had the highest overall turnover rate. Figure 17 shows the different types of turnover by regions.

Figure 17: Teaching staff turnover by region

Turnover rates were higher among education and care (16%) than kindergartens (7%), in 2025. In 2025, home-based services had the highest rates of turnover due to teaching staff moving to another ECE service (8%) and education and care services had the highest rates of turnover due to staff leaving ECE teaching altogether (5%). Figure 18 shows the turnover rates of three different service types, over the last four years.

Figure 18: Turnover rates of teaching staff by service type and year



Where to find out more

For more information about teaching staff in early learning see the Early childhood education staffing statistics page on Education Counts. For a large range of other early learning statistics see:

- [Factsheets on the annual ECE census](#)
- [Directory of ECE service providers](#)
- [Statistics on services or providers of ECE](#)
- [Statistics on staffing in the ECE sector](#)
- [Publications from the Monitoring and Evaluating the Early Learning Action Plan \(ELAP\) programme](#)
- [He Whakaaro: Estimating ECE teaching staff pay – 2018 to 2024](#)

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